

Heuristic Evaluation

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Part II: Project Description

Ecobnb is a web platform for sustainable tourism, connecting travelers with eco-friendly accommodations such as local bnb and green hotels. I am evaluating *Ecobnb* because it closely mirrors the goals of my own project: by studying it, I can understand how a green travel web app structures its eco-criteria, attracts sustainable hosts, and promotes responsible tourism.

Part III: Evaluation Execution

The heuristic evaluation of *Ecobnb* was conducted by accessing the website on a web browser, then on mobile. I used a checklist of established usability heuristics as the evaluation material, such as Nielsen's 10 heuristics, and systematically assessed the interface, navigation, content clarity, and accessibility. The evaluation followed a step-by-step approach: first exploring the homepage and main features, then testing search and planning functions, and finally reviewing labels information, usability, visualization and the design.

Part IV: List of Violations

Report the heuristics' violations you identified. Each of them must be numbered sequentially and formatted as follows:

1 H1 Visibility of system status

- **Where:** Search button on the homepage
- **What:** When clicking on Search, there is no visual or textual feedback, so users cannot tell if the action was successful or if the website is still loading.
- **Why:** Users are left uncertain about the system's status, violating the principle that the system should always keep users informed about what is happening.
- **Severity:** 3

2 H5 Error prevention

- **Where:** City search field on the search accommodations page
- **What:** When a wrong city name is entered, the system provides no feedback or suggestions, and instead displays a large number of destinations, which may not be relevant.
- **Why:** The system does not help prevent errors or guide the user to correct input, violating the principle that systems should prevent mistakes or offer corrective guidance.
- **Severity:** 3

3 H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design

- **Where:** Booking information section on accommodation pages
- **What:** Important information such as “No payment on Ecobnb – pay directly to the accommodation,” and details about contact requests and booking confirmation are displayed in colors that blend with the website theme, making them hard to notice.
- **Why:** The lack of visual emphasis on critical information reduces clarity and violates the heuristic that designs should be clear, minimalist, and highlight important content.
- **Severity:** 2

4 H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design

- **Where:** Header and footer across the website
- **What:** The header and footer have very light colors, making them hard to read, and some text elements extend beyond the container, breaking layout consistency.
- **Why:** Poor contrast and layout issues reduce readability and visual clarity, violating the heuristic that design should be aesthetically clear and well-structured.

- **Severity:** 1

5 H4 Consistency and standards

- **Where:** Mobile version of the website
- **What:** On mobile devices, there are two dropdown menus, and the footer disappears, causing navigation inconsistencies.
- **Why:** The interface behaves differently from the desktop version, breaking consistency and standard expectations for navigation elements.
- **Severity:** 4

6 H3 User control and freedom

- **Where:** Search page
- **What:** There is no clear way to return to the homepage; users can only click on the logo, but this is not obvious.
- **Why:** Users lack clear navigation options to control their movement within the website, violating the heuristic that users should be able to easily undo actions or navigate freely.
- **Severity:** 2

7 H7 Flexibility and efficiency of use

- **Where:** Login and registration process
- **What:** The login and registration process is split across multiple windows; for example, users first enter their email, navigate to the next page, and then enter their password, which slows down the process.
- **Why:** The multi-step process reduces efficiency, especially for experienced users, violating the heuristic that systems should allow users to achieve tasks quickly and flexibly.
- **Severity:** 3

8 H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design

- **Where:** Index (homepage) – Discover Offers section
- **What:** Sections are not clearly separated; for example, only a few offers are shown and users cannot see more unless they click on the “Discover Offers” link, which is not evident.
- **Why:** Poor visual separation and unclear navigation reduce clarity and make it harder for users to find content, violating the heuristic that design should be clear and intuitive.
- **Severity:** 1

9 H6 Recognition rather than recall

- **Where:** Tooltip on the accommodation rating (green leaves)
- **What:** The tooltip displays a long explanation about sustainability criteria, requiring users to read and remember detailed information to understand the rating.
- **Why:** Users must recall detailed content from the tooltip instead of the system presenting it in a simpler, more recognizable way, violating the heuristic of minimizing memory load.
- **Severity:** 2

Part V: Summary and Recommendations

Violations Summary

Report the total number of identified violations:

Heuristic	# Violations
H1: Visibility of system status	1
H2: Match between system and the real world	0
H3: User control and freedom	1
H4: Consistency and standards	1
H5: Error prevention	1
H6: Recognition rather than recall	1
H7: Flexibility and efficiency of use	1
H8: Aesthetic and minimalist design	3
H9: Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors	0
H10: Help and documentation	0
HN: Non-heuristic issue	0

General Impressions and Recommendations

Ecobnb is a visually appealing platform primarily focused on helping users search for green accommodations, with additional features like blogs and special offers. The website is generally clean and informative, making it easy for users to find eco-friendly options. Some usability issues reduce the overall experience, such as missing feedback when performing searches, low-contrast text in important sections, unclear navigation on mobile devices, and multi-step login processes that slow users down. To improve the interface, *Ecobnb* could add clearer feedback and error messages, enhance text contrast, streamline login and registration, and ensure consistent navigation across devices. Clearer sectioning for offers and intuitive navigation cues would also make the site easier to explore.